STEADFAST MEN

Lesson 07 · Live for a Reward That Lasts

Transcript · Wes Hart

Hey. Good to have you in the room. Uh, a man came through the door, looked the chairs over, and took the one aimed straight at the exit. I respect a man with an exit strategy. I have been that man. More than once. Glad the door shut behind you. Last lesson we talked about going first. Some of you moved while your stomach was still arguing. Some of you, uh, endorsed it from a very safe seat. This lesson isn't stacking another brave act on you. I want the pay inside the act.

For anybody who still doesn't have my name, I'm Wes. That's plenty. Now listen. You did not sit down empty. You sat down already aimed. Every man lives for a reward. The only question is which one.

You may not have a clean name for yours. You still check it. A message. A face. Whether the day treated you like you matter. Uh, I have steered by that check longer than I like to say, and I called it being grown. Some of it was. A lot of it was— a lot of it was me hunting a payment I could feel before supper. I mean, I could feel the payment. I just wouldn't call it that. You might be young, and the payment is whoever is impressed today. Or the house is full, and what you actually want is one hour nobody is allowed to touch. Or you're hurt, and you're waiting on a sentence a man may never say. I have worn each of those. They will not, you know, hold you. Small rewards pay. Then they run out. And somebody other than God is holding the lever.

Stay with me. We're gonna name the one that has the wheel. Then we're gonna look at a greater one. God's.

These marks are the sentence we keep coming back to. I have not improved them. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's.

Uh, you have heard the four. This lesson stays on the last line. Works for God's pay. Not the room's.

I'm not reopening the other three. You've, uh, been in them. Here is the only piece I need you to see. Those three cost a man something now. A man keeps paying that cost when he trusts the return is real. Take the return away, and the costly thing starts looking foolish. Uh, I know, because I have quit costly things when the only prize left was whether the room still liked me. The fourth mark is— the fourth mark is not a ribbon on the other three. It is the reason they survive a quiet stretch, when nobody is saying thank you.

So let me say the claim without a shine on it. Every man lives for a reward. The only question is which one.

You don't decide whether to want one. You walked in wanting one. The work in front of us is to stop lying about which. Some of you hear the word reward and you think it sounds small. Like it belongs to a lesser man. Uh, stay with that. I want it in the room. Because if you pretend you are above a reward, you will not notice the one that's already steering you. God is not embarrassed by the word. I mean, he offers a reward. He tells you to want a better one. He just refuses to be replaced by a smaller one.

Hold that last line. A steadfast man works for God's pay. Not the room's.

You can tell a man's reward by what he checks when the talk is over. Not the answer he would, uh, give me up here. The thing he reaches for in the first quiet minute. Uh, I have a little list. Not a holy list. A true one. Some of you are living, uh, for a fast reply. The little ping that says you are still needed. If it doesn't come, the afternoon sours. Some of you are living for a room that thinks you are the steady one. You will sand a whole story down until it leaves you looking calm. Some of you are living for an evening where nobody needs a thing from you. You will protect that hour like it is the prize of the day. Some of you are living to come out of a conversation as the sharp one. None of that is strange. Most of it is decent in its place. You know, the trouble is the steering. Let me tell on myself. A man I respect asked me a hard thing. I wanted my answer to sound calm. Biblical, even. I wrote it. Then I wrote it— I wrote it over again. Sanded the edge off. Tucked a verse in where it would make me look settled. Uh, I read it back and felt like a wise man. He wrote back two words. Got it. I stared at those words like they had cheated me. The verse didn't fail. The wage did. I was not after truth. I was after being seen as the man who handles hard things well.

A younger guy sat in a group with me. I'll call him Nate. He told a second story only if the first one got a laugh. If the room stayed quiet, uh, he went to his phone. I asked him what he was chasing. He said, if they laugh, I know I took up space. A room can become your paycheck. And a room goes home.

Here is what those rewards have in common. They do pay. That's why a man takes them. The reply feels good. The laugh feels good. Then they're gone, and the hunt starts again before you've left the chair. And you don't hold the lever. Another man can, uh, withhold the reply. The room can go flat. The hour you protected can get interrupted by a kid at the door, or a phone, or a real need. The person you wanted impressed can be thinking about supper. Uh, a small reward is real. It is just rented. Somebody else can take the keys back without warning you.

I learned that the embarrassing way. I got in the habit, uh, of staying after the work was already finished. Not because there was more to do. I straightened things that were straight. I wanted a certain man to double back and see me still there. He didn't. I went home sour at him for missing a show he was never told was playing. I stayed— I stayed for a witness who never signed up to be one. That's how small a wage can get and still run your evening.

Let me see your hands. How many of you have done a decent thing and then found a way to mention it before the day was over? Go on. This room can handle it. Yeah. I don't need the number. That's a reach I know. That reach for a witness is the small reward talking. It paid you, uh, in being seen. And being seen clocks out. God's pay is a different kind. It is not controlled by the man who might walk back in. It does not spoil because the room went home. If your whole pay can be cancelled by somebody's mood, you are underpaid, and you already know it.

Jesus did not teach us to quit wanting a reward. Uh, he aimed the wanting. Hebrews twelve, verse two. Fixing our eyes on Jesus, the pioneer and perfecter of faith. For the joy set before him he endured the cross, scorning its shame, and sat down at the right hand of the throne of God.

Stay on that line. For the joy set before him.

He did not endure— he did not endure because pain is holy. Pain was not the prize. The joy was. The cross was real. The shame was real. He scorned it. He did not pretend it was nothing. He went through it with a joy set in front of him, and he sat down.

That is a man with a reward in view. Not a mood. A joy ahead of him, strong enough to walk into what he would rather not carry. A lot of us have the math backward. We stare at what the hard thing will cost us today, and the cost is all we can see, so we don't move. Uh, I have done that with a conversation I owed somebody. I could list the cost. I could not see anything past it. So I kept my mouth shut and called it peace. I mean, the quiet felt spiritual. It was fear with a clean name. Jesus looked past the cost at the joy. That look is what let him endure. You can, uh, do a costly thing when a better joy is actually in front of you. You can hardly do it at all when all you can see is what you are losing.

So the verse does not say, grit your teeth, pain is the point. It says fix your eyes. Fixing. You know, not a glance on the way out the door. The joy was in front. The cross was on the way. He did not confuse the two.

Every small reward I named needs an audience. Somebody has to, uh, reply. Somebody has to laugh. Somebody has to be impressed, or sorry, or finally quiet. God's pay asks you to send the audience home.

Matthew six, verses three and four. But when you give to the needy, do not let your left hand know what your right hand is doing, so that your giving may be in secret. Then your Father, who sees what is done in secret, will reward you.

Uh, he's talking about a gift. The same eyes see the other hidden work. A thing done for the Father does not need a witness in the room to count. The room can miss it completely. He does not.

That rearranges a man. If the Father is the one who sees, you can do a good thing and leave it there. You don't have to pick it back up and walk it around until somebody notices. I am not, uh, naturally good at this. I filled a brother's car with gas while he was inside. Then I stood by the pump like the receipt was gonna introduce me. I almost— I almost tapped the gauge and said, you're welcome. Yeah. Two minutes of secret obedience, and I was already shopping for a witness. I wanted the Father to see it and I wanted my brother to see it, and those are not the same wage. Uh, Jesus was plain about the trade. Matthew six, verse one. Be careful not to practice your righteousness in front of others to be seen by them. If you do, you will have no reward from your Father in heaven.

You have been paid. Paid in being seen. And that pay is small. The moment you glance around to find out who noticed, you have cashed a check the Father did not write.

Secret does not mean sneaky. It means the audience is settled. One set of eyes. His.

Now some of you are thinking, that still sounds like a deal. Do the hidden thing, get a payout from God. I hear it, right? It can sound like a man working an angle on heaven. Uh, look at the payout before you decide. Matthew twenty-five, verse twenty-one. His master replied, Well done, good and faithful servant. You have been faithful with a few things. I will put you in charge of many things. Come and share your master's happiness.

Well done. More entrusted to you. Come and share my happiness. That is not a tip left on the table beside him. The reward is— the reward is him.

You are welcomed. You are trusted with more. You share his joy. A man who wants that is not running a hustle. He wants the Father glad. He wants to be brought in, not paid off. I mean, brought in. That is a different kind of pay. If the prize is a thing next to God, you will use God to get the thing. If the prize is God, the hard day is still pointed at a person. You were wanting him.

Uh, I have wanted the other arrangement. Do the right thing, and have the day get easier. Have people treat me fairly. Have the knot in my stomach leave. That is me hiring God. You know the deal. I have signed it. More than once. Sons don't hire their father. They want him pleased that they came the way he asked. So hear the verse as a welcome. Well done. Come and share your master's happiness. The happiness is his, and he shares it. You don't collect it and go live somewhere else. The local scoreboard cannot say well done in the voice you were made for.

There was a man in a group I sat with a long time. I'll call him Ellis. Quiet man. If something broke around the building, somebody said his name before they said what was wrong. Ellis will get it. He lived, uh, on that sentence more than he knew. I watched him stand up straighter when it got said in the hall. I watched him go dull if a long stretch passed and nobody called. Then some younger men took the building on. They didn't cut him down. They just, you know, stopped needing the sentence. Uh, Ellis got brittle. Skipped the group. I found him after a breakfast, standing by his truck. He said, I kept that place from coming apart, and now I don't know what I'm for. I asked him what the work had been paying him. He didn't want— he didn't want a speech. He looked at the ground a while. Then he said, being necessary. That was the whole pay. Being the man they couldn't skip.

Some time later I was in a grocery line. A woman ahead of me was talking about her dad. His eyes were gone. A man had been coming in the afternoons to read to him. Wouldn't leave a name. She said he had a knuckle that didn't sit right on his hand, and he smelled a little like cut wood. I knew the knuckle. Uh, I found him. I said I had heard about a man who reads. He went still. Then he got close to angry. Don't bring that to the group. The minute I tell it, I will start reading so you all think well of me.

That's the turn. He lost the sentence he had lived on. He did not go hunt a new audience. He put a good thing where the room could not pay him, and he guarded it. A man who got honest about his wage and moved it.

You don't have to interview a man to see which reward he's aimed at. Uh, it shows up in ordinary places. He does a good thing and he doesn't bring it back into the conversation. He can lose a point he might have won, because being the sharp one quit paying enough to be worth the damage. He stays on a day when a clean exit is sitting right in front of him, and he could explain the leaving to almost anybody. He takes the smaller place without checking who saw him sit there. He forgives a man who has not balanced the account, and he stops running the file. None of that makes much sense if the only pay is in this room. All of it makes sense if the Father is the one who sees, and the joy is still in front.

I lost a small argument with a friend. Not a crisis. I thought of the better line later, sitting in my truck. Said it out loud. The steering wheel never even argued. A man working for God's pay can let a point

go. I am still, uh, learning that one. The scoreboard in my head wants the last clean sentence. The Father is not impressed by it. Same mark. Different chair. Uh, if you're young, ask who you are performing for. That crowd will change its mind. I mean, if you're single, a wife is a gift when God gives one. She is not your pay. Don't make a woman the prize that finally finishes you. Uh, if you're married, she is not the prize either. If you've been working to impress her, or to be left alone by her, both of those are small, and she can feel which one has the wheel. If you're hurt, I mean, the sentence you're waiting on may never get said. Vindication is a small reward wearing a better coat. You can set it down. The Father saw what happened. You don't have to keep the file open to stay a man.

If the work is going well, good. Uh, I'm glad. Competence is not the problem. Taking your whole reward from being good at the work, that is the problem. They will tell you you're sharp. That word has, uh, a short life. You will always want more of it. If you're the older man, don't spend the years you have left managing the stories other people will tell. Uh, do the good. Let their mouths worry about the story. A long memory in somebody else's mouth is too small a wage. Now let me fence this in, because the counterfeit is loud. God's pay does not mean the hard thing leaves on your calendar. It does not mean she warms because you stayed. It does not mean the man who wronged you will ever say so. It does not mean your body eases up, or the year gets kind, or your kids become a story that flatters you at a table. It is not a better pile of things handed over for good behavior. Men who preached that deal left wreckage behind them. I have sat, uh, with the wreckage. A man obeys, the pain stays, and he feels cheated because somebody sold him the wrong prize. So if you are in a hard marriage, or a hard silence with a son, or a body that will not cooperate, this mark is not a scolding. It does not— it does not call your pain holy for its own sake. The cross stayed a cross. The joy was ahead of it, not instead of it. There is a Father who sees what nobody in the house is thanking you for. You can endure a thing without pretending it is light. If the joy is in front of you, you can stay without demanding the day get easy.

That is the order of the verse.

You'll feel the old reward try to take the wheel back. It usually starts, uh, with a glance. You do the decent thing, and then your eyes go looking for who caught it. Uh, that glance is the tell. You do have to notice which way your feet turn after it. Jesus already told you the math. Do it to be seen, and you are paid in full. Do it in secret, and the Father keeps the account. I mean, somebody is keeping a book. Make sure it is his. So here is the practice. One good thing that no one will ever know about. Not your wife. Not your brother. Not the men at these tables. If they hear it, uh, you spent it. If you hint — if you hint at it, you picked a thing that wanted a crowd. I have ruined a few this way. I did something decent for a neighbor and brought it up at supper like I was just thinking out loud. I said it was strange what people don't notice. My wife stayed quiet. She just, uh, didn't help me tell it. And I heard how small I was being. Some of you will do the hidden thing and then narrate it on the way out so it can stay humble and still get famous. It was advertising. If the story travels, it was the wrong good thing. The small reward is the part you say out loud. The hidden thing stays hidden. Mix those up and both of them die. How many of you can already feel the small one you'd rather keep vague? Hand up. No speech. Alright. Don't lose that on the way to the table. Vague is how a small reward survives a whole talk about it. Name it particular. Then do one thing the Father sees and this room never hears.

Let me say the whole thing in plain words, and then I'll, uh, get out of the way. Every man lives for a reward. The only question is which one.

Small rewards pay, and then they run out. The greater one is God himself. Well done. Come and share his happiness. I hope you— I hope you walk out of here with one honest sentence. You can name the small reward that has been steering you, and you can aim at a greater one, because the greater one is God himself.

Your workbook is open for that. In a minute you'll sit at the tables and work this part together. So get the questions in your ear the way you'll actually say them. Which small reward has been steering you, and where? Where have you been performing so someone would think well of you? What is one good thing you will do that no one will ever know about?

Uh, say the first one out loud. One sentence. Married men, she may already see it. Uh, say it anyway. Single men, don't skip it because the house is quiet. The steering still shows. Then, uh, the hidden thing. One. Nobody in this room gets the story, including the brother you trust. If you tell it, you spent it. Tell that brother the small reward and what it has cost you. Do not tell him the secret. If he can't ask you later whether you went back to the small one, you told the wrong man. And carry this. Every man lives for a reward. The only question is which one.

You've carried one sentence through this room. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's.

From this lesson on, expect that reward. Tables. Work that part of the workbook together. Start with the small reward. Say it plain.